

THE COMPLETE ANXIETY TOOLBOX

50 Evidence-Based Techniques in One Workbook

Cognitive | Physical | Behavioral | Acceptance | Lifestyle

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UNDERSTANDING YOUR ANXIETY PROFILE

Rate each (0=never, 5=always):

Physical symptoms: racing heart___ sweating___ trembling___ nausea___

Cognitive: racing thoughts___ catastrophizing___ indecision___ rumination___

Behavioral: avoidance___ reassurance-seeking___ procrastination___ checking___

Emotional: dread___ irritability___ restlessness___ overwhelm___

My primary anxiety type:

☐ Generalized (worry about everything)

☐ Social (fear of judgment)

☐ Panic (sudden intense attacks)

☐ Health (worry about illness)

☐ Specific phobia: _____

☐ OCD-related (intrusive thoughts + rituals)

☐ PTSD-related (trauma responses)

My anxiety level today (0-10): ____

My average this week (0-10): ____

My goal level (realistic): ____

COGNITIVE TECHNIQUES (1-10)

1. THOUGHT RECORDS

How: Identify thought > evidence for/against > balanced thought

When to use: When: caught in negative thinking loop

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

2. DECATASTROPHIZING

How: What's the worst/best/most likely? Can I cope with worst?

When to use: When: imagining worst-case scenarios

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

3. EVIDENCE TESTING

How: What facts support this? What facts contradict it?

When to use: When: believing something without proof

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

4. WORRY TIME

How: Schedule 15 min/day. Postpone worry until then.

When to use: When: worry interrupts your day constantly

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

5. COGNITIVE DEFUSION

How: I notice I'm having the thought that... (observe, don't fuse)

When to use: When: thoughts feel like facts

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

COGNITIVE TECHNIQUES (1-10)

6. REATTRIBUTION

How: What else could explain this? Not everything is about me.

When to use: When: personalizing or blaming yourself

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

7. PROBABILITY ESTIMATION

How: What's the actual % chance? (Usually <5%)

When to use: When: overestimating threat likelihood

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

8. RESPONSIBILITY PIE

How: Divide 100% responsibility - how much is actually yours?

When to use: When: taking on too much blame

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

9. BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENTS

How: Test your prediction. What actually happened?

When to use: When: avoiding because you predict disaster

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

10. SURVEY METHOD

How: Ask others: do they think/feel this too? (normalize)

When to use: When: believing you're the only one struggling

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

PHYSICAL TECHNIQUES (11-20)

11. DIAPHRAGMATIC BREATHING

How: Belly rises on inhale (4ct), falls on exhale (6ct)

When to use: When: panic symptoms, racing heart

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

12. 4-7-8 BREATHING

How: Inhale 4, hold 7, exhale 8 counts

When to use: When: can't fall asleep, pre-event anxiety

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

13. PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELAXATION

How: Tense each muscle group 5 sec, release 10 sec

When to use: When: body tension, headaches, jaw clenching

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

14. BODY SCAN

How: Slowly scan head to toe noticing sensations without changing

When to use: When: disconnected from body, floating anxiety

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

15. COLD EXPOSURE

How: Cold water on face/wrists activates dive reflex, slows heart

When to use: When: panic attack, intense emotion, need quick reset

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

PHYSICAL TECHNIQUES (11-20)

16. EXERCISE PRESCRIPTION

How: 20 min moderate cardio = anxiety reduction for 4+ hours

When to use: When: chronic tension, restlessness, rumination

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

17. YOGA/STRETCHING

How: Gentle poses with breath focus. Child's pose, cat-cow.

When to use: When: morning anxiety, body stiffness, need grounding

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

18. 5-4-3-2-1 GROUNDING

How: 5 see, 4 touch, 3 hear, 2 smell, 1 taste

When to use: When: dissociation, derealization, panic

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

19. BILATERAL STIMULATION

How: Tap alternating knees, butterfly hug, walk

When to use: When: stuck in distress, processing difficult emotions

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

20. VAGUS NERVE ACTIVATION

How: Hum, gargle, cold face, slow exhale

When to use: When: fight/flight stuck on, need to activate calm

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

BEHAVIORAL TECHNIQUES (21-30)

21. EXPOSURE HIERARCHY

How: List fears 0-10. Start at 3. Work up gradually.

When to use: When: avoidance is running your life

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

22. RESPONSE PREVENTION

How: Feel the urge. Don't do the ritual. Wait it out.

When to use: When: compulsive checking, reassurance seeking

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

23. BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION

How: Schedule activities even when you don't feel like it

When to use: When: avoidance + depression keeping you stuck

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

24. APPROACH GOALS

How: Move TOWARD what you want, not away from fear

When to use: When: all your goals are avoidance-based

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

25. SAFETY BEHAVIOR REDUCTION

How: Drop one safety behavior at a time

When to use: When: you only cope by controlling everything

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

BEHAVIORAL TECHNIQUES (21-30)

26. VALUED ACTION

How: What would you do if anxiety wasn't deciding?

When to use: When: anxiety is choosing your life for you

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

27. SOCIAL SKILLS PRACTICE

How: Script > rehearse > try in low-stakes situation

When to use: When: social anxiety from skill deficit

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

28. ASSERTIVENESS

How: I feel ____ when ____ because ____ I need ____

When to use: When: people-pleasing causes anxiety

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

29. PROBLEM SOLVING

How: Define problem > brainstorm > pros-cons > choose > act

When to use: When: anxiety comes from unsolved real problems

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

30. ACTIVITY SCHEDULING

How: Plan positive activities daily. Don't wait to feel better.

When to use: When: withdrawal is worsening your anxiety

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

ACCEPTANCE TECHNIQUES (31-40)

31. MINDFULNESS MEDITATION

How: Observe thoughts like clouds. Don't chase or push away.

When to use: When: daily practice to reduce baseline anxiety

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

32. ACT (ACCEPTANCE)

How: Make room for anxiety AND move toward values

When to use: When: fighting anxiety makes it worse

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

33. SELF-COMPASSION

How: Treat yourself like you'd treat a friend who's struggling

When to use: When: self-criticism amplifies anxiety

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

34. WORRY POSTPONEMENT

How: Write worry down. Promise to address at scheduled time.

When to use: When: worry interrupts work/relationships

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

35. ACCEPTANCE COMMITMENT

How: I accept anxiety is here. I commit to ____ anyway.

When to use: When: waiting to feel ready keeps you stuck

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

ACCEPTANCE TECHNIQUES (31-40)

36. RADICAL ACCEPTANCE

How: This is what is. Fighting reality adds suffering.

When to use: When: resisting unchangeable circumstances

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

37. DISTRESS TOLERANCE

How: I can feel this without acting on it. It will pass.

When to use: When: urge to escape is overwhelming

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

38. EMOTION SURFING

How: Ride the wave. It peaks and falls. Always.

When to use: When: panic/intense emotion feels permanent

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

39. METACOGNITIVE AWARENESS

How: Thoughts about thoughts aren't facts either.

When to use: When: worry about worry (meta-worry)

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

40. DEFUSION EXERCISES

How: Sing the thought. Say it in funny voice. Thank your mind.

When to use: When: intrusive thoughts feel powerful

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

LIFESTYLE TECHNIQUES (41-50)

41. SLEEP HYGIENE

How: Consistent time, dark room, no screens 1hr before

When to use: When: poor sleep worsens next-day anxiety

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

42. CAFFEINE AUDIT

How: Track caffeine intake. Reduce if >200mg/day.

When to use: When: physical anxiety symptoms won't reduce

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

43. SOCIAL CONNECTION

How: Schedule 1 meaningful interaction daily

When to use: When: isolation amplifies anxious thoughts

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

44. NATURE EXPOSURE

How: 20 min in nature reduces cortisol significantly

When to use: When: chronic stress, need nervous system reset

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

45. GRATITUDE PRACTICE

How: 3 specific things daily. Rewires negativity bias.

When to use: When: catastrophic thinking dominates

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

LIFESTYLE TECHNIQUES (41-50)

46. MEDIA DIET

How: Limit news to 15 min/day. Unfollow anxiety triggers.

When to use: When: doom-scrolling escalates worry

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

47. ROUTINE BUILDING

How: Predictable routine = less decisions = less anxiety

When to use: When: chaos in schedule creates overwhelm

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

48. BOUNDARY SETTING

How: No is a complete sentence. Overcommitment = anxiety.

When to use: When: saying yes to everything burns you out

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

49. VALUES CLARIFICATION

How: What matters MOST? Align actions with top 5 values.

When to use: When: anxiety comes from living misaligned

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

50. MEANING & PURPOSE

How: Find your why. Anxiety decreases when purpose is clear.

When to use: When: existential anxiety, feeling directionless

Practice notes: _____

Effectiveness (1-10): ____ Will use again? [] Yes [] No

MY TOP 10 ANXIETY TECHNIQUES

After trying techniques, record your top 10 go-to tools:

1. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
2. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
3. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
4. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
5. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
6. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
7. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
8. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
9. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____
10. Technique: _____
Best for (situation): _____
How quickly it works: _____

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - WEEK 1

Mon: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Tue: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Wed: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Thu: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Fri: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sat: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sun: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Week average: ___/10 Best day: ____ Pattern noticed: _____

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - WEEK 2

Mon: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Tue: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Wed: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Thu: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Fri: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sat: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sun: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Week average: ___/10 Best day: ___ Pattern noticed: _____

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - WEEK 3

Mon: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Tue: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Wed: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Thu: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Fri: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sat: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sun: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Week average: ___/10 Best day: ____ Pattern noticed: _____

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - WEEK 4

Mon: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Tue: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Wed: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Thu: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Fri: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sat: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Sun: Level ___/10 Trigger: _____

Technique used: _____ Result: ___/10

Week average: ___/10 Best day: ___ Pattern noticed: _____

MY ANXIETY ACTION PLAN

When anxiety is 1-3 (mild):

I will: _____

When anxiety is 4-6 (moderate):

I will: _____

When anxiety is 7-8 (severe):

I will: _____

When anxiety is 9-10 (crisis):

I will: _____

Daily prevention routine:

Morning: _____

Afternoon: _____

Evening: _____

Professional support:

Therapist: _____

Psychiatrist: _____

Crisis line: 988

My commitment: _____